



HEY KIDS: *Slinky meets a real live Dragon!*

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The Animality

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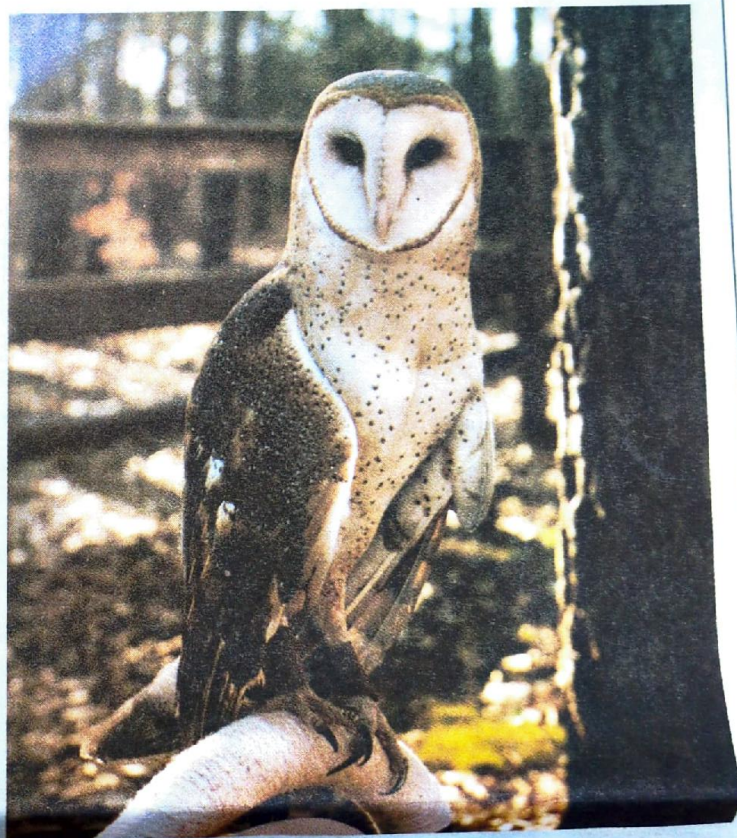
A Sweetheart Among Owls

by Joyce LiBethe, Ph.D

Randall is a sweetheart and a barn owl. Barn owls are affectionately referred to as sweetheart owls because of their heart-shaped faces. The feathers forming the heart shape of their faces are called the facial disc. Facial discs are found in varying shapes on the faces of all owls. Their function, much like that of a satellite dish, is to gather sounds so that the owl can hunt effectively in near darkness.

Randall resides along with other raptors such as hawks, eagles, and vultures at the Carolina Raptor Center. Raptors are birds of prey with curved beaks and razor-sharp talons. The Carolina Raptor Center is a non-profit tax exempt organization dedicated to educating the public on the importance of

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raptors, to the rehabilitation of injured, sick, and orphaned raptors and to research which would improve the plight of these magnificent birds. The birds which are brought to the Raptor Center are reared or rehabilitated, then released if they are able to survive on their own. Those birds whose injuries prevent them from being able to fly or hunt may become permanent residents. Like Randall, they may be seen on the nature trail at the Raptor Center or in public programs provided on and offsite.

Randall fractured his left wing when he was in his first year of life. Because it healed shorter than his right wing, it causes him to fly in circles. Randall was most likely hit by a car, which is the most common reason for owls being brought in for rehabilitation. It is believed that litter thrown from cars attracts rodents to the sides of roads. Of course, the owls hunt where the food source is. Unfortunately when an owl spots his prey and swoops in, he doesn't look for oncoming traffic.

Randall is also considered a sweetheart because of his endearing parental skills. Over the last two years he has successfully been foster-daddy to four orphaned barn owl babies, and has raised along with a mate, Flo, three owlets of their own. As with most raptors, it is often difficult to tell the sex of a bird. Color and size are assessed to make a gender judgment. This is not always accurate. Flo was originally named Floyd until she produced a clutch of eggs! After Flo and Randall raised their young, the young were released into the wild.

Habitat loss and climate changes throughout the country are reducing the number of barn owls, making them a nationally protected species. Their declining numbers are

of special concern to the state of North Carolina. Barn owls, like other owls, do not build nests. Some owls take over abandoned nests of crows or hawks, but the barn owl prefers to lay eggs directly on bare wood or stones in silos, barns or hollow trees. To compensate for habitat loss, people are encouraged to supply breeding boxes in areas where there are rodents, the barn owls' food of choice.

Seven species of owl are known to live or at times winter in North Carolina. Of these species, the Barn, Barred, Great Horned, Short-Eared, and Screech Owls can be seen at the Raptor Center. Since many of us have heard owls but few have seen them in their nocturnal activities, it is a special treat to observe them up close. One of the reasons that it is so difficult to spot owls at night is that they fly in silence. Usually soft and fringed feathers help the owl to fly silently. This provides the element of surprise when they attack their prey. Owls usually eat their prey whole. The nutritious portion is digested and those portions that are not, such as the bones, claws and hair, are cast out as tightly condensed pellets. Many school children dissect these pellets as part of science class and they are also sold at the gift shop at the Raptor Center.

Another favorite resident at the Raptor Center is Dumbo, a Barred Owl with no physical problems. Dumbo has a different kind of problem which prevents his release. He is imprinted on humans. There is a critical period in a young bird's life when it learns certain behaviors and what kind of creature it is by who is caring for it. The concept is referred to as imprinting. Because Dumbo was found being mobbed by other birds when he was very young, a family began caring for him. As a result, he was imprinted on humans and Dumbo believes he is a human. He has no idea about hunting. If he were to be released, he would fly to the

nearest human whenever he wanted to eat — a behavior that would certainly get him into a lot of trouble. Not only that, but when a young male bird's fancy turns to love in the spring, you guessed it. Dumbo is very attracted to one of the female workers at the Raptor Center. Typical of his species in attempts to court her, he offers her the only gift he has — a mouse. As cute as this story may sound, it is sad for Dumbo, who will never really know the true life of an owl.

If you should ever see a young owl on the ground, watch for the parents before doing anything. They will often feed the owl where it is. Using its talons and beak the owl has a good chance of climbing back to safety. If the bird is not being cared for, or is in danger, and cannot be put back into the nesting area, call the Carolina Raptor Center at (704) 875-6521.

*Become a volunteer
and get to know
these raptors
personally.*

Owls are protected by federal and state regulations, making it illegal to kill, capture, or possess one. Xat, pronounced "Cat", came to the center after being confiscated by a highway patrolman. The man possessing this Great Horned Owl was stopped for speeding on his way to a location in Indiana, where he was to have Xat killed and made into a lamp. In her attempt to escape from the box in which she was being transported by this man, she did permanent damage to her eye. In addition to acute hearing, the eyes of an owl are very important for hunting success and the ability to fly swiftly through a wooded area. Each eye of the Great Horned owl is as large as its brain. If our eyes were as large in proportion to our bodies, they would be as large as softballs. Owls eyes are unable to move within their sockets. Since the owls can swivel their heads 270 degrees in either direction, they don't need to move their eyes!

If you would like to gaze your eyes upon these owls, the Raptor Center is open 10 AM to 5 PM Tuesday through Sunday. Better yet, become a volunteer and get to know Randall, Dumbo, and Xat personally. If you want to help the owls but don't have time for volunteering, you can "adopt" one or have a brick, inscribed with your name or message, installed in the walkway at the center. The Carolina Raptor Center is located at Latta Plantation Park on Sample Road off of Beatties Ford Road. It can be reached by taking I-77 to exit 16B, then following the signs into the park.

Dr. LiBethe is a clinical psychologist and a volunteer at the Carolina Raptor Center.